The view championed by the leaders of the Congress in the early twentieth century with respect to the Indian diaspora was: ‘make Burma thine home’, ‘make Ceylon thine home’ and ‘make Malaya thine home’. [34] As explained by a former foreign secretary, ‘Gandhi and Nehru and the Congress did not want the overseas Indian to want or claim the best of both worlds. If you lived in Burma, treat Burma as your home, live and move and have your being in Burma, do not cast covetous eyes on India, not all the time. Your loyalties were to be towards the country of your adoption. When the Congress came into power in 1946–47 the entire outlook on overseas Indians was based on this theoretical viewpoint.’ [35]

Before championing the Indian independence struggle, Mahatma Gandhi fought for the rights of Indians and other immigrants in South Africa. It is interesting that he fought for their rights to be treated as South African subjects of the British Crown, not as Indian citizens.[36] Both Gandhi and Nehru believed that once someone left their country and based themselves in another homeland, they should be expected to integrate themselves with their adopted country. An Indian living abroad would remain Indian in a cultural and civilizational sense but he or she was now the responsibility of their new country, not of India.

Nehru voiced that view whenever the issue of the Indian diaspora was raised in the Constituent Assembly right after Independence, resulting in discussions on Indians in South Africa, Burma and Sri Lanka. In his speeches, Nehru praised those who went abroad as merchants, traders, workers, indentured labourers and students, worked hard and managed to do well in life. ‘They worked hard for themselves, and for the country of their adoption. They made good themselves and the country they had gone to also profited. It is a romance and it is something which India can be proud of.’[37]

The first prime minister of India recognized the perils of xenophobia in many of the countries to which Indians had emigrated. ‘India is a country